

Sequences

Sometimes composers repeat melodies note for note, but at a higher or lower pitch than the original. This repetition is called a sequence.

SEE ALSO

◀ 48–51 Sharps and flats

◀ 56–59 Intervals

◀ 76–79 Transposition

Diatonic and chromatic harmony 122–123 ▶

Simple sequencing

In many familiar folk tunes, sequencing at a higher or lower pitch interval is used to vary repetitions of the same material. The reuse of melodic ideas—starting on different pitches, but using similar jumps in pitch between notes—brings cohesion to the music.

▽ “A-hunting we will go”

Written in 1777 by Thomas Arne for *The Beggar’s Opera*, this tune has become a favorite melody in folk songs and nursery rhymes.

The same melody is sequenced by transposing up a major third to start on scale degree 3, or *mi*.

New material with similar rhythmic character.

Combines the pitches of the first two phrases in a climb back down to 1 or *do*.

Sequencing at an interval

Composers use sequencing at a variety of intervals. Here a simple ascending scale is sequenced once at an interval of a perfect 4th. The entire motif—melodic fragment or phrase—is repeated, but starts four scale degrees higher.

▽ Sequence 1

This fragment starts on scale degree 1 or *do*, moving up the scale. The next fragment maintains upward run of notes motion, beginning on 4 or *fa*.

Starts on 1 or *do*

Starts on 4 or *fa*

Scale degree 1

Scale degree 2

Scale degree 3

Final feel, ends on tonic

1 2 3 4

67 ▽ Sequence 2

The same simple motif is shown below. An upward run of notes is sequenced four times, moving up a whole step each time.